How One Ohio Town Became the Center of the Data Center Debate

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In the small Ohio village of Mt. Orab, farmland next to family homes has become the center of a statewide debate. Property records show that about 1,000 acres of farmland and trees there were sold to a data center developer in 2024 and 2025. Construction has not begun yet, and it is not clear when it will start.

Leading the local pushback is Nick Owens, a lifelong Republican and small-town attorney from nearby Brown County. He says **nondisclosure agreements** have made it hard for residents to learn details about the project. He teamed up with another local attorney and a real estate agent who shared his worries, and together they helped build Conserve Ohio, a volunteer network reaching nearly all of Ohio's 88 counties, with Democrats, Republicans, and independents.

This fall, the group is backing **ballot measures** in 10 communities that would change local **charters** to block large-scale **data centers**, the huge computing sites used to power artificial intelligence. It is also collecting signatures for a proposed **amendment** to the state constitution that would ban such centers across Ohio, aiming to put it before voters in 2027.

Supporters point to benefits such as **tax revenue**, money for schools, and construction jobs, though the number of permanent jobs is smaller. Critics, including Owens, worry about secrecy, constant noise, pollution, and new power plants the sites may require. Owens says he would consider placing **data centers** on old industrial sites, away from homes, instead of on farmland.

The issue has also entered Ohio's race for the U.S. Senate, where former Senator Sherrod Brown and incumbent Senator Jon Husted have traded criticism over past support for **data centers**. Meanwhile, volunteers like Linda Moodie, an independent, are collecting signatures at community events, including a Halloween celebration in Fairfield on October 22.

Word Treasure

nondisclosure agreements -- Agreements that stop people from sharing certain details about a project.

ballot measures -- Votes that let people decide a question or a change to local rules.

charters -- The basic rules that set how a local community governs itself.

amendment -- A formal change added to a constitution or set of rules.

data centers -- Huge computing sites that store information and power services such as artificial intelligence.

tax revenue -- Money a government collects from taxes and can spend on public services.

Background you need

Data centers are large sites filled with computers that store information and run online services, including tools that use artificial intelligence.

Because they need a lot of space and electricity, building one near homes can raise questions about noise, pollution, and new power plants.

A local charter sets the basic rules for a community, and voters can sometimes change those rules through ballot measures.

A state constitution sets the basic rules for a whole state, and changing it usually starts with collecting signatures and putting the question to voters.

Break it down

LEAD: Farmland in Mt. Orab sold for a data center has become the center of a statewide debate.

KEY EVENT: Local pushback led by Nick Owens grows into the volunteer network Conserve Ohio.

+- WHO: Nick Owens, another local attorney, a real estate agent, and volunteers including Linda Moodie.

+- WHAT: Ballot measures in 10 communities and signatures for a proposed state constitutional amendment to ban large-scale data centers.

+- WHEN: This fall for the ballot measures, with the amendment aiming for a vote in 2027.

EVIDENCE: Property records show about 1,000 acres sold in 2024 and 2025, and construction has not begun.

OPEN QUESTION: When, if ever, construction will start, and whether voters will block large-scale data centers.

Why it matters

Where large computing sites are built affects nearby homes, farmland, and electricity use, so local votes and state rules can shape whole communities.

Test what you remember

1. About how much farmland and trees in Mt. Orab were sold to a data center developer?

- (A) About 100 acres
- (B) About 88 acres
- (C) About 10,000 acres
- (D) About 1,000 acres

2. Who is leading the local pushback against the data center project?

- (A) Jon Husted
- (B) Nick Owens
- (C) Linda Moodie
- (D) Sherrod Brown

3. What is Conserve Ohio, as described in the article?

- (A) A state court
- (B) A data center developer
- (C) A volunteer network reaching nearly all of Ohio's counties
- (D) A power company

4. In how many communities is the group backing ballot measures this fall?

- (A) In 88 communities
- (B) In 27 communities
- (C) In 2027 communities
- (D) In 10 communities

5. What would the proposed amendment to the state constitution do?

- (A) Require data centers to be built on farmland
- (B) Create a new county
- (C) End all ballot measures
- (D) Ban such centers across Ohio

6. What alternative did Owens say he would consider?

- (A) Stopping all construction in Ohio
- (B) Building data centers on old industrial sites away from homes
- (C) Building more power plants next to homes
- (D) Moving the project to another state

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: B 3: C 4: D 5: D 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Supporters of data centers: They point to benefits such as tax revenue, money for schools, and construction jobs, though the number of permanent jobs is smaller.

2. Critics, including Nick Owens: They worry about secrecy, constant noise, pollution, and new power plants the sites may require, and Owens would prefer old industrial sites away from homes.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):